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MAKE MY OWN LIGHT



Poems from the dark, and the turning toward

BY MK PARRISH · \$12

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*For anyone reading this in the dark. Your light is worth keeping lit. I promise,
and I always keep mine.*

01

REAL

I am scared of the future.
They say to live in the present,
that it is a gift,
so why do I feel the weight of it
in every task I cannot finish?

I try to numb a ghost of pain.
It haunts me anyway,
every day, in every possible
miserable, ordinary way.

I dwell on the loss.
I dwell on the leaving.
When deep inside the only true line is this:
I am lost, and I am still here,
and both of those are real.

FREE FALLIN'

Every night I stare at the building,
the lit one, the famous one,
the one that says a city is a thing
you can climb your way out of.

Then one night I look over
and it is me on the ledge.
Falling. Free-falling.
I used to love that song
before it was a forecast.

But here is what the falling taught me:
the ground was never the ending.
The ground was the floor
I had been too high up
to remember was there.

LIVE, DON'T MERELY EXIST

I cannot count the years I spent existing.
That is how old I am.

Existing is not a feeling.
It is the careful absence of one.
A beautiful apartment.
The curtains drawn against the view.
A girl who called the numbness peace
and starved inside the quiet.

I want freedom. Independence.
Honesty. Belief. Faith.
I do not want the looming lies anymore,
the eternal harbinger of almost.

So I open the curtains.
The view is still there.
It was always still there.

THE MAN IN THE MOON

I have a man in the moon now.
He lives in the dark inside me
until I am ready to sparkle.

We were apart my whole life
and you were still the closest thing
to a place that felt like home.
Now I talk to you on Flatbush,
where you were born,
and I make up your answers
the way I once made up
the endings to the stories
you were not there to finish.

The medium has not changed, Old Man.
Only the direction.

HAVING A SMOKE

Morning cigarette, the two of us,
except I am the only one holding anything.

You told me once that things
are only worth the value you put on them.
I fought you on it. I was wrong.
They sold your signed name after you left
and it did not fetch much,
a few packs of city smokes,
and I sat down on the curb and laughed
because you could not have written the sign
any clearer if you had hired the sky.

I get it now, Dad.
I am sorry it took the whole afterlife
to teach the book-smart girl
one street-smart thing.

BLISS IS IGNORANCE

Bliss is ignorance.

It is the most precious gift,
and only the few naive ones,
the ones like me,
ever throw it all away
trying to see clearly.

But I have decided
I would rather see
and ache
than be comfortable
and asleep.

THE VALUE OF VALUE

I know the value of value now.
The strength it takes to keep the stride.
The top of the mountain,
and the long loss of a senseless soul
who never did learn
the weight of grief
or the cold arithmetic of deceit.

No one taught me to stand alone.
They held my hand when I walked.
I moved through life like a playland
and got further in the game
than I had any right to.

Confidence is a gift
I am learning to give myself,
since no one ever wrapped it for me.

BURN THE GRIEF

Someday my light will shine,
and not because a hand reached down
and lit me as a pretense,
a small flame offered in exchange
for my surrender.

No.

I will make my own light.
I will let it burn the grief
I carry daily
for the love and the life I once knew.

I will never dim another soul
to make my own look brighter.
I will never hand you a flashlight
and then send you the bill.
I will only ask the ones
whose light is made of the same stuff,
love and truth,
to help me set fire to a sky
that has stayed dark for too long.

STREET SMART

Why are you so book smart, you asked,
and not street smart at all?

I did not have the answer then.
I have it now,
and it cost me everything
the answer is usually worth.

I can read a room before it speaks.
I know the difference
between a person who is
and a person who performs.
I know which loves are load-bearing
and which are only decorative.

I learned to breathe.
You told me to, in all capitals,
over and over,
on the nights I could not.
I am breathing, Dad.
Look. I am breathing.

YOU ARE NOT ALONE

You signed off the same way every time,
shouting it across the distance
so it would carry:

You are not alone.

I did not believe you then.
I am learning to believe you now.

You filled a hole in my heart
I had carried so long
I had stopped calling it a wound
and started calling it my shape.
And the wild thing,
the thing that undoes me still,
is that you wrote and told me
I had filled one in yours.

So we were two people
with matching holes
and eleven months

to fit them together.

It was not enough.

It was everything.

TO BE CONTINUED

I should be crying in the dark, they think,
grateful for the last of the light
that leaked from the ones who left me here.

No.
That is not how this story goes.
That is not how MY story goes.

I will not abandon
the few specks of gold
I must still have
somewhere inside me.

I am still here.
Despite the pain, the sleepless years,
the names they typed with hashtags,
the love that turned out
to be decorative after all.

I am still here.
And this girl,
with the tears still wet on her face,

would not have it any other way.

To be continued
is just a longer way
of saying
I survived.

A note, from me to you. If a poem here found you in the dark, please do not stay there alone. In the United States you can call or text 988, any hour of any day, and reach a real person who wants you to stay. Make your own light. The world needs the specific color of yours.

♡ MK

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